

Chapter 1 – Introduction to Google Workspace

Learning Objectives

After completing this chapter, you should be able to:

- Understand what Google Workspace is.
 - Explain how a Google Workspace tenant is structured.
 - Differentiate between Google Workspace and Google Cloud Platform.
 - Understand the core services.
 - Explain licensing and editions.
 - Understand Google's cloud architecture at a high level.
-

1. What is Google Workspace?

Google Workspace is Google's cloud-based productivity and collaboration platform.

It provides organizations with secure communication, collaboration, identity management, storage, and administration through a single cloud platform.

Think of Google Workspace as the digital workplace for an organization.

Instead of maintaining on-premises servers such as:

- Microsoft Exchange
- File Servers
- Active Directory
- Video Conferencing Servers

Google hosts and manages these services in its cloud.

Users simply connect over the Internet.

Business Problem

Imagine a company with 5,000 employees.

Without Google Workspace, the company might need:

- Exchange Server

- File Server
- Active Directory
- VPN
- Backup Infrastructure
- Spam Filtering Server
- Video Conferencing Solution

Managing all of these requires hardware, maintenance, upgrades, backups, and security.

Google Workspace replaces much of this operational overhead with managed cloud services.

Enterprise Example

ABC Technologies

Employees: 5,000

Before Google Workspace

- Exchange Server
- Windows File Server
- Skype for Business
- Local Backup Server
- Physical Storage
- VPN

After Google Workspace

- Gmail
- Google Drive
- Google Meet
- Google Chat
- Google Calendar
- Admin Console

No email servers.

No storage servers.

No collaboration servers.

Google manages the infrastructure.

2. What is a Google Workspace Tenant?

A tenant is a dedicated Google Workspace environment belonging to one organization.

Think of it as the company's private workspace in Google's cloud.

Example

Company A

Domain

companyA.com

Tenant contains:

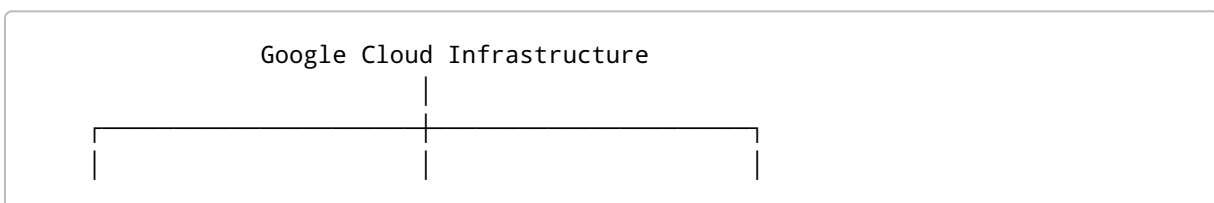
- Users
- Groups
- Organizational Units
- Shared Drives
- Security Policies
- Gmail
- Drive
- Meet
- Calendar
- Admin Roles

Everything belongs to that tenant.

Another company has its own separate tenant.

Data is logically isolated between organizations.

Tenant Architecture



Company A Tenant Company B Tenant Company C Tenant | | | Users & Data Users & Data Users & Data

Google operates the infrastructure.

Each organization controls only its own tenant.

Real Enterprise Example

XYZ Corporation

Primary Domain

xyz.com

Secondary Domains

xyz.co.uk

xyz.in

xyz.au

One Google Workspace tenant manages:

- 22,000 users
- 900 groups
- 400 Shared Drives
- 12 Organizational Units
- Multiple security policies

Although multiple domains exist, they all belong to one tenant.

3. Google Workspace vs Google Cloud Platform (GCP)

Many people confuse these products.

They solve different business problems.

Google Workspace	Google Cloud Platform
Collaboration Platform	Infrastructure Platform

Google Workspace	Google Cloud Platform
Gmail	Virtual Machines
Drive	Cloud Storage
Meet	Kubernetes
Calendar	Databases
Chat	Networking
Admin Console	Cloud Console

Google Workspace manages people and collaboration.

Google Cloud manages applications and infrastructure.

Example

HR wants email.

Use:

Google Workspace.

A software developer wants to host an application.

Use:

Google Cloud Platform.

Many organizations use both together.

4. Core Google Workspace Services

The most common services include:

Gmail

Business email.

Example

rahul@company.com

Features

- Email
 - Spam Filtering
 - Routing
 - Security
 - Compliance
-

Google Drive

Cloud storage.

Stores:

- Documents
- PDFs
- Images
- Videos
- Spreadsheets

Supports:

- Sharing
 - Version History
 - Collaboration
-

Google Meet

Video conferencing.

Features

- HD Meetings
 - Screen Sharing
 - Recording (edition dependent)
 - Noise Cancellation
 - Live Captions
-

Google Chat

Business messaging.

Supports

- Direct Messages
 - Spaces
 - File Sharing
 - Bots
 - Integrations
-

Google Calendar

Scheduling platform.

Supports

- Meetings
 - Resource Booking
 - Shared Calendars
 - Availability
 - Invitations
-

Google Docs

Word processor.

Supports

- Real-time collaboration
 - Comments
 - Suggestions
 - Version History
-

Google Sheets

Spreadsheet application.

Supports

- Functions
- Charts
- Collaboration
- Connected Sheets
- Pivot Tables

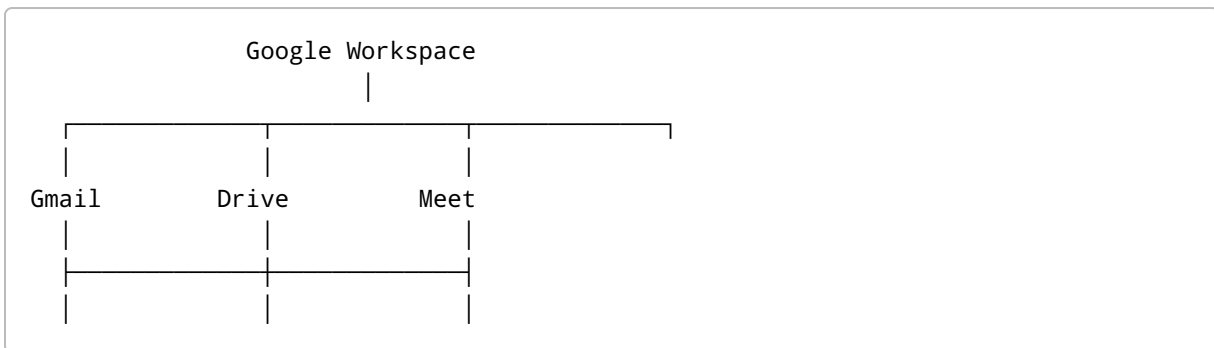
Google Slides

Presentation software.

Supports

- Team collaboration
- Presentations
- Templates
- Speaker Notes

Service Relationships



Calendar Chat Admin Console

All services are connected through the user's identity.

5. Identity is the Foundation

Google Workspace is identity-centric.

Every service begins with the user identity.

User



Authentication



Authorization



Google Services



Audit Logs



Security Policies

If the identity is compromised, every connected service is affected.

This is why identity security is one of the most important aspects of Workspace administration.

6. Google Workspace Editions

Google offers different editions with different capabilities.

Edition	Best For
Business Starter	Small businesses
Business Standard	Collaboration and storage
Business Plus	Growing organizations
Enterprise Standard	Large organizations
Enterprise Plus	Advanced security and compliance

Enterprise Plus includes features such as:

- Security Center

- Investigation Tool
 - Context-Aware Access
 - Advanced DLP
 - Google Vault enhancements
 - Enterprise Endpoint Management
-

Example

Company with 20 employees

Business Standard

Company with 40,000 employees

Enterprise Plus

The correct edition depends on business and security requirements.

7. The Admin Console

The Admin Console is the central management interface.

Administrators can manage:

- Users
- Groups
- Domains
- Devices
- Apps
- Security
- Billing
- Reports

Think of it as the control plane for your tenant.

Example Tenant

Company

Contoso Ltd.

Primary Domain

contoso.com

Tenant contains

Users

- Alice
- Bob
- Charlie

Organizational Units

- HR
- Finance
- Engineering

Groups

- hr@contoso.com
- finance@contoso.com
- engineering@contoso.com

Applications

- Gmail
- Drive
- Meet
- Calendar

Security

- 2-Step Verification
- Context-Aware Access
- DLP
- OAuth Restrictions

Everything is administered from a single Admin Console.

Best Practices

- Design your tenant before adding users.
- Use Organizational Units for policy management.
- Use Groups for collaboration and permissions.
- Apply the Principle of Least Privilege to admin roles.

- Enable security features appropriate for your edition.
 - Plan naming conventions for users, groups, and Shared Drives.
-

Common Mistakes

- ✗ Treating Groups as Organizational Units.
 - ✗ Giving everyone Super Admin access.
 - ✗ Ignoring license planning.
 - ✗ Not designing an OU structure.
 - ✗ Not reviewing security settings after tenant creation.
-

Interview Questions

1. What is a Google Workspace tenant?
 2. What is the difference between Google Workspace and Google Cloud Platform?
 3. Why is identity considered the foundation of Google Workspace?
 4. When would you recommend Enterprise Plus over Business Standard?
 5. What is the role of the Admin Console?
-

Chapter Summary

In this chapter you learned:

- ✓ What Google Workspace is.
- ✓ How a tenant is structured.
- ✓ The relationship between users, identities, and services.
- ✓ The difference between Google Workspace and Google Cloud Platform.

✓ Core services provided by Google Workspace.

✓ Editions and licensing.

✓ The purpose of the Admin Console.

The next chapter will focus on **Identity Management**, where we'll explore users, Organizational Units, Groups, Admin Roles, delegated administration, and enterprise tenant design in depth.